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MIGRANTS' DISTRESS

30 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 1,116 ACTIVE CASES | 33 DEATHS

WORLD | 6,80,870 CASES | 40,639 DEATHS

When the country locked down, the expectation was that all people, from all strata of society would be compelled to bend over backwards and stay put where they were for the next three weeks in national interest, or in the prime minister's words, '*Joh jahaan hai, wahi rahein* (Wherever you are, stay put).' Unfortunately, for daily wage workers and migrants, the idea of spending three weeks without a wage was scarier than the fear of coronavirus. Possibly because they knew how debilitating hunger could be versus not having enough information on the morbidity of the new disease. Compounding this was the fear of the unknown disease and if infected they wouldn't know where and if they would be treated. In a situation of so many unknowns, several of them craved for the comfort of their villages and their families. Something as basic as being able to stay put with a full stomach was now being viewed as an unaffordable luxury.

Migrants are the backbone of India's workforce. Over the years, over a hundred million people have migrated to the urban areas in search of work. They work largely in informal sectors as helpers in urban homes and shops, cleaners, construction workers, masons, factory workers and such. Although, looking deeper into this demography it is revealed that there are two kinds of migrants who set out to the cities to look for work: long-term migrants and short-term migrants. Long-term migrants are those who have a considerably stable employment in a certain field of work and have been in that particular city for over 10 years. On the other hand, short-term migrants are those who move to cities only for about four to six months but keep